

Situation, complication, question, answer

Start where the reader already agrees, say what changed, raise the question that change puts in their mind, and answer it. The opening that earns the rest.

FOR A PIECE OF WRITING · THE CONSULTING INTRODUCTION, 1970S · TAKES TWENTY MINUTES FOR THE OPENING

HOW TO RUN IT

1. Write who the reader is and what they already know and agree with. The opening is built from their side, not yours.
2. Situation. One or two sentences of what is true and uncontroversial. The reader should nod.
3. Complication. What has changed, gone wrong, or come up. This is the reason the piece exists.
4. Question. The question the complication raises in the reader's mind. Write it as they would ask it. If it isn't the question you're answering, one of them has to change.
5. Answer. Your answer, in one sentence. This is the end of the opening and the start of the argument.
6. Below the answer, the reasons, grouped and ordered by strength, with the evidence at the leaves. That structure is Answer First, and it has its own card.

Where it falls down. A situation the reader doesn't agree with, which loses them in the first sentence, or a complication invented to make the answer look necessary.

WITH A PEN

The reader, and what they already believe

Situation

What is true and uncontroversial. They nod

Complication

What changed. Why this piece exists

Question

In the reader's words

Answer

One sentence. The argument hangs beneath it

The reasons beneath, in order of strength

See the Answer First card for the rest